School & System Element Specifications

Career-Connected Learning Implementation

General Specifications

The following guidance applies to all activity and practice categories. Career-connected learning is a K–14 system, not a set of isolated programs. All school- and system-level elements must be designed to:

- ➔ Assume every learner is capable of multiple futures and deserves access to high-value experiences
- ➔ Function across grade bands, sites, and transitions, including post-graduation
- ➔ Reduce friction for students and families by embedding wayfinding into core systems, not optional add-ons
- ➔ Ensure access by default, not by exception
- ➔ Enable continuous improvement through shared data, reflection, and iteration

Districts, CMOs, and networks are largely responsible for coherence, infrastructure, and sustainability, while schools are largely responsible for day-to-day implementation, relationships, and student experience.

Curriculum, Instruction, & Assessment Align what students learn and how they demonstrate learning to real-world applications and future goals.	
What this can look like: • Career-aligned interdisciplinary projects • Performance tasks assessed by educators and external partners • Pathway-specific capstones and exhibitions • Digital portfolios demonstrating skill progression • Competency-based credit and • advancement	General Guidance: • Anchor curriculum design in a graduate profile aligned to postsecondary and workforce demands • Prioritize applied, interdisciplinary learning connected to real-world problems • Use authentic assessments with clear criteria tied to skills, not seat time • Allow multiple demonstrations of mastery • Ensure curriculum coherence across grade bands and transitions • Define systemwide learning outcomes (graduate profile or learner competencies) that explicitly include career-connected skills (e.g., self-direction, problem-solving, professional communication). • Map curriculum vertically (K–14) to ensure early exposure builds toward later pathway depth, rather than repeating disconnected activities. • Identify where and how career-connected learning shows up in required coursework versus electives; ensure it is not limited to optional programs. • Map which demonstrations of learning count for credit, advancement, or credentialing, and codifies those decisions in policy. • Ensure alignment with postsecondary partners so dual-credit, credential, and capstone expectations are coherent and transferable.

	K–2	3–5	6–8	9–10	11-14
	• Story-based learning, play, and role exploration • Demonstrations through drawings, talk, and performance tasks	• Project-based units connected to community and careers • Rubrics emphasizing collaboration and problem-solving	• Applied projects tied to interests • Portfolio artifacts introduced and reflected upon	• Pathway-aligned coursework and dual credit • Performance assessments tied to industry-aligned skills	• Capstones, internships, and credential-aligned assessments • Exhibitions with postsecondary and employer audiences

Additional Design Guidance & Tools:
- Competency-Based Education Policy Map

School Community & Culture

The learning environment consistently communicates that every student belongs, every pathway has value, and exploration is expected.

What this can look like:
- Alumni murals and pathway visibility
- Decision Day celebrations honoring all postsecondary paths
- Mentorship programs and advisory communities
- Houses or cohorts that build belonging

General Guidance:
- Automate marketing campaigns; create email and text campaigns triggered by key milestones (e.g., PSAT scores released, FAFSA opens, pathway selection process begins, and more)
- Maintain a 12-month editorial calendar aligned to the wayfinding roadmap; consider using a theme for packaging each quarter (e.g., “Explore,” “Apply,” “Launch”)
- Segment audiences (students, families, alumni, employers) and tailor tone, platform, and call-to-action for each
- Track open, click-through, and conversion rates for site-based and system-based communications.
- Provide all assets in the most prevalent community languages and ensure ADA-compliant alt text, captions, and contrast ratios.
- Establish shared language and norms for postsecondary success that staff, students, and families consistently use.
- Audit participation data for high-value experiences (internships, dual credit, leadership roles) and address opportunity gaps through targeted supports.
- Design rituals and celebrations intentionally, ensuring apprenticeships, military service, employment, entrepreneurship, and college are honored equally.
- Create structures for peer connection and belonging, especially during key transition years (5→6, 8→9, 12→13).
- Train adults to normalize exploration and revision, so changing interests or pathways is treated as learning rather than failure.

K–2	3–5	6–8	9–10	11-14
• Use play, storytelling, and imagination to help learners see themselves as future	• Introduce career curiosity corners with rotating artifacts, tools, and stories. • Highlight alumni and	• Create structured opportunities for peer-to-peer connection and identity exploration.	• Reinforce belonging during pathway selection through advisories, peer ambassadors, and	• Continue to honor milestones across a variety of future paths. • Leverage alumni and

	contributors. • Highlight many kinds of work and community roles through books, dress-up days, and classroom visitors. • Celebrate helping behaviors, curiosity, and persistence as early career skills. • Reinforce belonging through classroom jobs, routines, and recognition.	community members connected to student communities and identities. • Celebrate students' contributions to the school community publicly and often. • Begin naming "pathways" and "options" without asking students to commit.	• Make middle school a clear exploration zone, where trying and revising interests is expected. • Provide early, repeated messaging about future choice points without pressure. • Ensure every student has access to at least one adult advocate or mentor.	family engagement. • Celebrate exploration, informed choice, and goal-setting, not just achievement. • Make student leadership visible across pathways (not only academic honors). • Use schoolwide rituals to reinforce that all postsecondary plans are valued.	near-peer mentors to reinforce belonging beyond graduation. • Normalize non-linear transitions (e.g., gap years, stacked credentials, part-time enrollment). • Support identity shifts from "student" to "professional" through mentorship and culture cues.

Additional Design Guidance & Tools:

- RISE Center – Belonging & Identity Development Tools
- Edutopia – Student Voice & School Culture Practices
- Linked Learning Alliance – Pathway Culture & Equity Guidance
- Jobs for the Future – Equity-Centered Career Pathways Resources

Schedule & Use of Time

Time is intentionally designed and flexibly used to support exploration and experience across practice and activity categories.

What this can look like:

- Protected advisory periods for goal-setting, reflection, and planning
- Flexible bell schedules (block days, early-release days, late starts) that enable off-campus learning
- Dedicated time for work-based learning, site visits, and dual

General Guidance:

- Identify non-negotiable time blocks for advising, reflection, and planning at each grade band.
- Decide where flexibility is required (early release, late arrival, block scheduling, asynchronous learning) to enable off-campus experiences.
- Align bell schedules and calendars with postsecondary institutions and employers wherever possible.
- Plan for transportation time explicitly when scheduling internships, site visits, or dual enrollment.
- Protect advising and work-based learning time from being repurposed for remediation or test prep.

K–2	3–5	6–8	9–10	11-14
• Short, predictable blocks for	• Dedicated time within core subjects for	• Exploratory rotations or flex periods that	• Regular advisory blocks for pathway	• More dedicated time for internships,

enrollment • Built-in reflection time following experiential learning • Staggered schedules that allow students to participate in internships without missing core instruction • Summer, intersession, or extended-year options for credential attainment or exploration	exploration embedded within the school day. • Time allocated for storytelling, play, and discussion related to work and community roles. • Schedules prioritize routine and emotional safety while allowing for curiosity-driven exploration.	project-based exploration connected to community and careers. • Periodic flexible blocks for guest speakers, virtual field trips, or schoolwide exploration events. • Reflection time is built into projects to help students articulate their interests and learning.	allow students to sample interests and pathways. • Advisory time focused on reflection, identity development, and early planning. • Schedule structures that support off-campus exposure (site visits, career days) without loss of instructional time.	selection, planning, and skill-building. • Block or modified schedules that allow for college visits, job shadows, and short-term work-based learning. • Flexibility for students participating in early dual enrollment or credential coursework.	apprenticeships, dual enrollment, or credential attainment during the school day. • Built-in time for reflection, supervision, and transition planning. • Flexible pacing to support non-linear pathways, part-time enrollment, or stacked credentials.

Additional Design Guidance & Tools:

- Aurora Institute – Flexible Scheduling & Competency-Based Time Use
- Advance CTE – Work-Based Learning Scheduling Models
- National Academy Foundation – Internship & Early Release Case Studies
- CompetencyWorks – Credit Flexibility & Seat-Time Waivers

Adult Roles, Hiring, & Learning

Adults are prepared, supported, and organized to guide students through postsecondary pathways.

What this can look like:

- Clearly defined advising, pathway coordination, and work-based learning roles
- Dedicated staff (or protected time) for employer and postsecondary partnerships
- Advisor caseloads designed for coaching, not compliance
- Cross-functional teams (counselors, teachers,

General Guidance:

- Determine which responsibilities live at the system level (e.g., partnership management, data systems) versus the school level.
- Clearly define roles and responsibilities related to advising, pathway coordination, employer engagement, and postsecondary transitions.
- Align job postings and hiring processes to include coaching, relationship-building, and navigation skills.
- Provide structured professional learning on career-connected pedagogy, advising conversations, and labor market awareness.
- Protect adult time for coordination, relationship-building, and reflection, rather than expecting this work to happen “on top of” teaching.
- Create feedback loops so educators can surface challenges with pathways, partners, or systems and see those issues addressed.

K–2	3–5	6–8	9–10	11-14

coordinators, administrators) supporting pathways • Shared tools and protocols for advising, referrals, and follow-up • Ongoing professional learning tied to career-connected learning priorities • Near-peer, alumni, and industry mentors are integrated into adult support structures.	• Classroom teachers and families serve as primary guides for curiosity and identity-building. • Teachers receive age-appropriate career-exposure resources and coaching. • Adults emphasize belonging, contribution, and imagination rather than planning.	• Teachers integrate exploration into core instruction with system-provided materials. • Counselors or advisors begin light-touch exposure and reflection conversations. • Adults receive support to communicate with families about the long-term continuum.	• Advisors or counselors are trained in interest development and early planning. • Teachers collaborate with advisors to connect learning to emerging pathways. • Adults help students reflect on interests and experiences without pressure to commit.	• Dedicated pathway teachers, advisors, and counselors coordinate closely. • Staff support students through pathway selection, dual credit, and early credentials. • Adults guide students and families through key decision points and tradeoffs.	• Internship coordinators, transition advisors, and mentors support launch and persistence. • Adults help students navigate postsecondary systems, applications, and workplace norms. • Structures support intentional management of alumni relationships to support transitions and feedback loops.

Additional Design Guidance & Tools:

- Jobs for the Future – Career Advising Frameworks & Tools
- Advance CTE – Career Advising & Coaching Resources
- Linked Learning Alliance – Role Profiles & Staffing Models
- Learning Forward – Professional Learning Standards

Family & Community Partnerships

Families and community partners are co-designers and co-educators in students' career journeys.

What this can look like: • System-managed partnerships with employers, postsecondary institutions, and community organizations • Clear pathways for partners to engage as guest speakers, mentors, project partners, internship hosts, or	General Guidance: • Centralize partnership strategy at the system level to reduce the burden on individual schools and ensure quality and equity. • Clarify partner roles (guest speaker, mentor, internship host, co-assessor) and provide onboarding and support. • Design family engagement around decision points, not just events (e.g., pathway selection, credential choices, postsecondary transitions). • Provide families with clear, jargon-free information about options, tradeoffs, and supports. • Compensate or otherwise support partners when expectations go beyond limited exposure. • Collect feedback from families and partners and use it to refine experiences and communication.

	K–2	3–5	6–8	9–10	11-14
co-assessors • Family workshops tied to key decision points (pathway selection, credentials, applications, transitions) • Alumni and near-peer mentors supporting exploration and transition • Shared planning tools and calendars for schools, families, and partners	• Invite families and community members to share stories about their work and contributions. • Focus engagement on helping families understand the long-term continuum of career-connected learning. • Keep interactions informal and relational.	• Host family workshops and showcases that highlight concrete ways to support exploration and skill-building. • Introduce community partners through projects, virtual visits, and demonstrations. • Support families in beginning to talk with students about interests and strengths.	• Engage partners in structured exploration activities (career days, site visits, project critiques). • Provide families with clear information about upcoming choice points and options. • Offer multilingual, accessible sessions to support family understanding and participation.	• Engage employers and postsecondary partners in job shadows, short-term work-based learning, and pathway-aligned projects. • Support families through pathway selection and early postsecondary planning. • Ensure partners reflect students' identities and labor market opportunities.	• Coordinate internships, apprenticeships, dual enrollment, and credential programs with partners. • Engage families in postsecondary transition planning, including applications, enrollment, and persistence. • Leverage alumni and near-peer mentors to support launch and early postsecondary success.

Additional Design Guidance & Tools:

- CCSSO – Family & Community Engagement Toolkits
- Advance CTE – Family Engagement & Employer Partnership Resources
- StriveTogether – Partnership & Community Collaboration Frameworks
- U.S. Chamber of Commerce Foundation – Employer Engagement Tools
- Jobs for the Future – Equity-Centered Partnership Design Resources

Space & Facilities

Physical spaces support applied learning, collaboration, and professional identity development.

What this can look like:	General Guidance:
• Flexible classrooms that can be reconfigured for projects, collaboration, and presentations • Pathway-aligned labs, studios, and maker spaces (e.g., health,	• Inventory existing spaces and determine which can be repurposed for career-connected learning before building new ones. • Align facility decisions to pathway priorities, not aesthetics alone. • Design spaces that support multiple uses, including instruction, collaboration, presentations, interviews, and applied learning. • Ensure accessibility and safety, particularly in labs and maker spaces. • Display student work and pathways to reinforce culture and visibility. • Increase access to industry-aligned facilities by sharing specialized spaces across schools or partners.

	K–2	3–5	6–8	9–10	11-14
engineering, media, advanced manufacturing) • Shared-use spaces for interviews, mentoring, and professional meetings • Exhibition areas for student work, capstones, and portfolios • Industry-inspired design elements that reinforce professional norms and expectations • Joint-use or partner-hosted facilities that expand access to specialized equipment and environments	• Play-based exploration spaces that allow for movement, building, and imagination. • Classroom layouts that support storytelling, role play, and hands-on activities. • Visual displays that highlight a wide range of community roles and contributions.	• Flexible project spaces for hands-on learning and collaboration. • Areas to display student projects and learning processes. • Shared spaces for demonstrations and visiting community members.	• Collaborative workspaces that support exploratory projects and teamwork. • Introductory labs or maker spaces designed for safe skill sampling. • Spaces that support peer interaction and identity development.	• Pathway-aligned labs, studios, or classrooms that mirror professional environments. • Presentation and critique spaces for project exhibitions. • Interview or meeting rooms for mentoring, advising, and employer engagement.	• Advanced labs, studios, or partner-hosted facilities aligned to credentials and industry standards. • Dedicated spaces for internship preparation, professional practice, and reflection. • Flexible spaces that accommodate part-time enrollment, dual enrollment, or adult learners.

Additional Design Guidance & Tools:

- Edutopia – Designing Learning Spaces for Applied Learning
- MakerEd – Maker Space Planning & Safety Guides
- Project Lead The Way – Pathway-Aligned Space Design Examples
- National Clearinghouse for Educational Facilities (NCEF)

Technology & Tech Infrastructure

Technology systems enable exploration, planning, documentation, and continuity from K–12 into postsecondary.

What this can look like:

- 1:1 devices for students beginning no later than middle school
- Shared or classroom-based devices for early grades
- Single sign-on access to interest inventories, planning tools, and learning platforms
- Cloud-based student portfolios

General Guidance:

- Select platforms that integrate across grade bands and follow students through graduation and beyond.
- Establish clear data-sharing policies with postsecondary partners while maintaining privacy and security.
- Plan device distribution, maintenance, and replacement centrally to ensure reliability and equity.
- Ensure required platforms are accessible, multilingual, and device-agnostic when possible.
- Train students and staff to use technology for planning, reflection, and professional communication.
- Codify post-graduation access to portfolios, credentials, and records.

K–2	3–5	6–8	9–10	11-14
• Optional tablets or	• Shared computer	• Full 1:1 devices or	• Full 1:1 device access.	• Full 1:1 device access

that persist across schools and into postsecondary • Secure data bridges between K–12 SIS platforms and postsecondary or workforce systems • Virtual tools for campus tours, workplace exploration, and career simulations • Hotspots or other connectivity supports for students without reliable home internet	shared devices used for storytelling, career videos, and simple digital exploration. • Technology use is limited, purposeful, and supports imagination and play. • Emphasis on unplugged, tactile learning experiences.	carts or classroom devices. • Introduction to simple digital reflection tools and interest exploration activities. • Guided use of technology to build foundational digital literacy.	reliable shared access. • Introduction of cloud-based portfolios. • Use of planning tools for interest exploration and goal-setting. • Explicit instruction in responsible and professional digital communication.	• Device-agnostic LMS linking coursework, dual credit, credential prep, and résumé builders. • Secure communication tools for advising and counselor access. • Increased student ownership of digital planning and documentation.	with expectations for professional use. • Advanced portfolio development tied to capstones, credentials, and internships. • Student tech squads or paid roles supporting troubleshooting and system upkeep. • Continued access to platforms during postsecondary transition and early persistence.

Additional Design Guidance & Tools:

- ISTE – Standards & EdTech Planning Tools
- CoSN – EdTech Infrastructure & Interoperability Frameworks
- Future Ready Schools® – District Technology Planning Resources
- EdSurge – EdTech Evaluation & Procurement Guides

Communications

Communications make the school-to-career journey visible, navigable, and actionable.

What this can look like:

- A unified brand and narrative for career-connected learning used across schools and departments
- Clear, milestone-based communications that guide students and families through exploration, decision points, and transitions

General Guidance:

- Develop a unified narrative on career-connected learning that is consistently applied across schools and departments.
- Identify key milestones (exploration, pathway selection, applications, FAFSA, transition) and build communications around them.
- Decide which messages are centralized and which are school-specific.
- Segment audiences and tailor tone, language, and channels accordingly.
- Track engagement metrics and adjust strategies based on what different audiences actually engage with.

K–2	3–5	6–8	9–10	11-14
• Use picture-heavy, family-friendly	• Send clear, visual communications	• Share early and repeated	• Provide clear, timely communications	• Deliver targeted, time-sensitive

• Multilingual, ADA-compliant materials delivered through multiple channels (email, SMS, web, social media, print) • Student, alumni, and employer stories that illustrate diverse pathways and outcomes • School- and system-level calendars highlighting key dates and opportunities • Two-way communication tools that allow families and students to ask questions and get timely support	communications that emphasize exposure and imagination. • Share simple stories about different kinds of work and community roles. • Focus messaging on helping families understand the long-term continuum of opportunities.	inviting families to workshops, showcases, and exploration events. • Begin naming "pathways" and "options" in accessible, low-pressure ways. • Highlight student projects and curiosity-driven learning.	communications about upcoming choice points and options. • Use multilingual formats to ensure families understand pathway structures and timelines. • Highlight student voices and peer experiences to normalize exploration.	about pathway selection, dual credit, and early credentials. • Highlight student accomplishments and experiences across pathways. • Use multiple channels to ensure students and families do not miss key deadlines.	communications related to FAFSA, applications, enrollment, internships, and credentials. • Feature alumni and near-peer stories to illustrate postsecondary transitions. • Use SMS and other direct channels to support completion of critical steps.

Additional Design Guidance & Tools:

- HubSpot – Content Calendar & Campaign Planning Templates
- Twilio – SMS & Email Automation Guides
- Harvard Kennedy School – Strategic Communications Resources
- Edutopia – Family Communication Best Practices

Budget & Operations

Funding and operational systems guarantee access to high-value experiences without burdening families.

What this can look like:

- District- or system-funded interest inventories, planning platforms, and advising tools
- Coverage of dual credit tuition, textbooks, and credential exam fees
- Transportation provided for site visits, job shadows, internships, and college courses
- Paid student roles (peer

General Guidance:

- Braid funding streams intentionally and document how each supports career-connected learning.
- Eliminate student fees for required components and plan for sustainability beyond grants.
- Budget for transportation, materials, and credentials upfront, not as afterthoughts.
- Centralize purchasing and contracting to reduce costs and ensure equity.
- Codify partner cost-sharing and expectations in MOUs.
- Maintain streamlined systems for background checks, stipends, and reimbursements.

K–2	3–5	6–8	9–10	11-14
• Budget per-pupil funds for storybooks, props,	• Budget for project materials, kits, and exploration	• Budget per-pupil funds for exploratory supplies and	• Budget for dual credit textbooks, lab consumables, and	• Budget for advanced credentials, certifications, and

mentors, tech squads) that double as work experience • Centralized purchasing of software, equipment, and assessment tools • Opportunity funds that cover application fees, work attire, or emergency needs • Clear operational workflows for partnerships, stipends, and reimbursements	and hands-on materials tied to exploration. • Support volunteer coordination for classroom visits and exposure activities.	resources. • Provide transportation for any off-campus exposure activities. • Centralize purchasing to ensure consistent access across classrooms and schools.	experiences. • Secure transportation for site visits, career days, and community-based learning. • Cover costs associated with introductory credentials or experiences where applicable.	credential exam vouchers. • Fund transportation for college visits, job shadows, and short-term work-based learning. • Provide stipends or paid roles for students supporting school operations tied to pathways.	dual enrollment costs. • Provide transportation or stipends for internships, apprenticeships, or employment. • Maintain centralized internship databases with e-signature workflows. • Fund systems for alumni tracking and postsecondary persistence support.

Additional Design Guidance & Tools:

- Advance CTE – Braiding & Blending Funds Toolkit
- Jobs for the Future – Funding & Sustainability Resources
- NASPO – Cooperative Purchasing Best Practices
- U.S. Department of Education – ESSA, Perkins V, & WIOA Crosswalks

Continuous Learning & Improvement

The system uses evidence to expand access, improve quality, and adapt over time.

What this can look like:

- System dashboards that track participation, access, and outcomes in real time
- Clear definitions of success aligned to career-connected learning goals
- Regular student, family, and educator feedback cycles
- Data-informed adjustments to pathways, partnerships, and

General Guidance:

- Define a small set of core metrics that track access, participation, and outcomes across K–14.
- Disaggregate data regularly to identify where opportunities are uneven.
- Establish routines for reflection with students, educators, and partners.
- Use improvement cycles (e.g., PDSA) to test changes and scale what works.
- Share data transparently with stakeholders and explain how it informs decisions.
- Include workforce demand and student interest data to guide pathway evolution.

K–2	3–5	6–8	9–10	11-14
• Use anecdotal observations and	• Use pre- and post-exploration	• Conduct mid-year plan audits to review	• Conduct semester reviews of pathway	• Track internship participation,

supports • Transparent sharing of progress and improvement priorities • Continuous refinement of programs based on workforce demand and student interests	simple indicators to track curiosity, engagement, and self-expression. • Monitor early literacy and numeracy as foundational indicators. • Gather informal feedback from students and families about interests and experiences.	reflections to gauge awareness growth. • Track participation in exploration activities across classrooms and schools. • Collect family feedback on understanding of opportunities and supports.	student exploration and planning progress. • Use reflection surveys tied to experiences such as site visits or projects. • Monitor equitable access to exploratory opportunities and supports.	enrollment, credit accumulation, and early credentials. • Track completion of planning milestones (e.g., pathway selection, postsecondary plans). • Use student and family feedback to improve advising and communication.	completion, and performance. • Monitor credential attainment, postsecondary enrollment, and year-one persistence. • Maintain alumni tracking systems to inform pathway refinement and partner alignment. • Use feedback from employers and postsecondary partners to improve program quality.

Additional Design Guidance & Tools:

- Education Strategy Group – Continuous Improvement & Theory of Action Tools
- Jobs for the Future – Career-Connected Learning Metrics & Data Resources